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Kinship

Descent, Kinship Terminology & Alliance

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What is Kinship?

- Has to do with two types of relationship
  - **Consanguineal Relationships** – Blood
  - **Affinal Relationships** - Marriage
- Every society classifies various categories of relationships into these two
- This classificatory system, with its associated social relationships and obligations is called the Kinship System

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Importance of Kinship in Simple Societies

- In Western or modern societies, kinship plays less / no role in the complex set of political, economic and religious associations.
- But in small scale societies, the social importance of kinship is enormous
- Here's how...

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Kinship in Simple Societies

1. Determines individual's social status
2. It determines where he lives, his group is, his membership, whom he should obey, who should obey him, his friends, his enemies, what he inherits and where he can pass on his possessions
3. A means to identify and order the multifarious social relationships
4. A mechanism through which facts of parenthood and bonds of mutual obligations are acknowledged
5. There is no other way, apart from sex and age, except kinship, to classify different people

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Nature of Kinship

1. Kinship Relations are not Biological Relations

- Biologically, even animals possess kinship
- But, unlike animals, humans consciously define social relationships
- In fact, when anthropologists define kinship, though they recognize any existence of biological relation, they only emphasize the social relations

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Nature of Kinship

2. Kinship Relations are Not a "Type" of Social Relationships

- They are many types of social relations like economic, political and religious
- However, kinship relations are not a "type" of social relations but are the contexts in which other economic, political and religious categories work
- Kinship provides the meaning for many other types of social relationships

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Nature of Kinship

3. Kinship System is the whole way of Life

- Kinship system is not just a collection of distinct and mutually exclusive terminology
- It is rather a whole way of life
- It is the reflection of human values
- It is the context in which humans and their cultures thrive to survive

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Rules of Descent

- Two Types
  - Unilineal / Unisexual Descent
    - Patrilineal Descent
    - Matrilineal Descent
  - Cogantic Descent
    - Double Descent
    - Bilateral Descent

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Structural Principles of Kinship - Robin Fox

- They are called the structural principles because the manner in which these conditions are fulfilled shape the structure of the kinship system

1. Men Impregnate Women
2. Women Bear Children
3. Men Control Economic Activities
4. Incest is a Taboo

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Kinship Terminology

- In every society, an individual occupies a specific social status
- This social status is a part of a group or a family
- A set of terms designate the individual's status within the groups to which he belongs - Kinship Terms
- The whole classificatory system is called as Kinship terminology

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Classification of Kinship Terms

1. **By mode of use**
2. **By Linguistic Structure**
3. **By Range of application**

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Mode of Use

- Terms of DIRECT REFERENCE
- Terms of INDIRECT ADDRESS

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Linguistic Structure

1. Elementary Terms
2. Derivative Terms
3. Descriptive Terms

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Range of Application

1. Denotative Terms
2. Classificatory Terms

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Analysis of Kinship Terminology

- Kinship systems all over the world use some criteria while employing a term.
- **A.L. Kroeber & R.H Lowie** have done a pioneering work in analyzing this criteria and identified the following:

1. Generation
2. Sex
3. Affinity

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Analysis of Kinship Terminology

4. Collaterality (Lineal relatives are more close then lateral relatives - Merging)
5. Bifurcation (sex of the connecting relative)
6. Relative age
7. Speaker's sex - Haida
8. Decedence - Red Indians

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Descent & Alliance

- Alliance system involves marriage rules through which descent groups are linked
- It is the universality of Incest Taboo that gives rise to alliance systems - **Claude Levi Strauss**
- Since people cannot mate / marry within their own descent groups, they have to depend on other descent groups for their mates
- Thus, marital alliances are social forces that promote wider alliances between descent groups.

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Classification of Kinship Systems - Levi Strauss

- Kinship Systems are classified into two types
- Elementary Structures
- Complex Structures

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Elementary Structures of Kinship

- Elementary Structures are those systems where kinship terminology itself determines a circle of consanguines and a circle of affines
- They are dominated by prescribed marriage system
- He hence calls them **Closed Systems** of Kinship

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Complex Structures of Kinship

- These are kinship systems where only the circle of consanguines or "relatives" are defined
- The choice of finding a spouse is left to "other mechanisms"
- Hence, he calls this an **Open System** of Kinship

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Solidarity Theory

- Alliance is crucial and inevitable mechanism for integration of society
- Once alliance relationships are established, they are usually perpetuated
- Hence, there is a **Solidarity** between the groups

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Types of Elementary Systems

- Levi Struass classifies elementary structures of kinship into two types
  - Restricted Exchange
  - Generalized Exchange
- Cross Cousin Marriage is the **most elementary form of exchange**

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Restricted Exchange

- Restricted Exchanges are usually found in societies with **dual organizations** called **moieties** (Fr: Half)

- This type involves a direct exchange between two groups; say A gives a woman to B and B in turn reciprocates with a woman to A.

- This type of exchange is **Symmetrical** as "wife-givers" are also "wife-takers"

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Bilateral Cross Cousin Marriages

- Restricted exchange gives rise to **Bilateral Cross Cousin Marriage**
- A bilateral cross cousin is a woman who is both a mother's brother's daughter and also father's sister's daughter
- Happens when ego's paternal aunt and maternal uncle marry each other
- In these systems, kinship terminology only differentiates a parallel or cross cousin without having to identify if they are patrilateral or matrilateral

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Generalized Exchange

- If there are only two groups involved in restricted exchange, in generalized exchange, there are multiple groups
- It is more indirect form of exchange as if A gives a woman to B, B to C and so on, at some stage one of the group in the chain gives a woman to A and closes the cycle
- This is an **Assymetrical system** of exchange because "wife-givers" and "wife-takers" are not the same

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Generalized Exchange

- If Restricted Exchange is found in societies with dual organizations, with bilateral cross cousin marriages, Generalized Exchange is often found in societies that practice unilateral cross cousin marriages.
- The kinship terminology system, in such societies, differentiates between patrilateral and matrilateral cross cousins.

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On Matrilateral Cross Cousin Marriages

- If alliance system is based on MBD's marriage, it sets in motion a **circulatory connubium** and is a **continous process**
- FZD's marriages are discontinous
- Levi Strauss says **matrilateral cross cousin marriages are more popular than patrilateral cross cousin**
- This is because it establishes relationships between several groups of people in a connubial cycle and **promotes social integration**

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Complex Structures

- In complex structures there are no marriage rules
- It may be a result of combination of all elementary structures, putting all forms of kinship structures on a same continuum

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Schneider & Homans - Sentiment Hypothesis

- It is the distribution of jural authority that determines the choice of one's wife
- In case of a patrilineal society, jural authority rests with the father - a situation of patriarchy
- As an extension, even the father's sister also wields considerable jural authority
- Whereas in these societies, mother, and as an extension, the mother's brother have considerable "affectionate" relationships with ego

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Sentiment Hypothesis

- As a consequence, the ego prefers the mother's brother's daughter to the father's sister's daughter for a wife.
- The corollary is true is case of the matrilineal societies.
- However, since the patrilineal societies are more compared to matrilineal societies, matrilateral cross cousin marriages are more popular in the world.

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Demographic Hypothesis - Rose & Reid

- Since women usually marry and reproduce at an earlier age than their brothers, their children are likely to be older than their brother's children.
- Hence, it is easy for a man to find women of younger and appropriate age only amongst his mother's brother's daughters, thus contributing to the popularity of matrilateral cross cousin marriages in the world.

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